offence. They stood on either side of the wall, appraising each other.

'Do you want to buy it?'

'No', he said.

'Well' she said,'If you don't want to buy the house, what are you looking at?'

'I used to live here twenty-five years ago. As a boy. As a young man.... And then my grandmother died, and we sold the house and went away.'

1. What was the old house built with?
2. Does the visitor still live in the house?

She was silent for a while, taking in this information. Then she said, 'And you'd like to buy it back now, but you don't have the money?' He did not look very prosperous.

'No, I wasn't thinking of buying it back, wanted to see it again, that's all. How long have you lived in it?'

'Only three years,' she smiled.

'Would you like to come in and look more closely?'

'Wouldn't your parents mind?'

'They've gone to the club.' They won't mind. I'm allowed to bring my friends home.'

'Even elderly friends like me?'

'How old are you?'

'Oh, just middle aged, but feeling young today.' And to prove it he decided he'd climb over the wall instead of going round to the gate. He got up on the wall all right, but had to rest there, breathing heavily.

'Middle-aged man on the flying trapeze,' he muttered to himself.

'I'll help you,' she said, and gave him her hand.

He slithered down into a flower-bed, shattering the stem of a hollyhock.

As they walked across the grass he spotted a stone bench under a mango tree. It was the bench on which his grandmother used to rest, when she was tired of pruning rose bushes and bougainvillea. 'Let's just sit here,' he said. 'I don't want to go inside.'

She sat beside him on the bench.

They were silent for some time. The man closed his eyes and remembered other times - the music of a piano, the chiming of a grandfather clock, the constant twitter of budgerigars on the veranda, his grandfather cranking up the old car....

'I used to climb the jackfruit tree,' he said, opening his eyes.

DO YOU KNOW?



A flying trapeze is a circus act in which people swing from one end of the circus tent on ropes.

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